SEND WITH THE SCRIPT

Self-recording guide

Reality-TV confessional style: you sit and talk to the camera, deadpan. No interviewer, so prop up your own phone, or let whoever sent you this hold it, and record it in five minutes whenever you have a free moment.

Setup

- **Nobody films you.** Prop your phone horizontal against a stack of books or a mug, at face height, about an arm's length away. Sit in a chair against a plain wall or a bookshelf.
- **Light:** face a window or a lamp. Don't sit with a window behind you.
- **Eyeline:** look just to the side of the lens, as if a producer is sitting next to the phone. Glancing at the lens once or twice is fine.
- **Tone:** deadpan beats hammy. You are a sincere person who has nothing to hide and is slightly annoyed to be asked.

Recording

- **The script:** read it from a second screen or a printout taped just under the phone. The *(beat)* and *(pause)* marks are where the laughs live. Hold them longer than feels natural.
- **Takes:** two max. Send the slightly flubbed one. Don't edit anything.
- **Length:** 60 to 90 seconds. Start recording, wait two seconds, begin. Stop two seconds after the last line.
- **Send it:** text or AirDrop the raw video to whoever sent you the script. They add the title card and load it onto the classroom laptop.

Making the script yours

Words in [brackets] are adjustable. The box at the top of your script sorts them: a few **must match the case file** (your clothing color, the time, a shoe size), because the kids cross-check what you say against printed evidence; if one of those is wrong for you, tell whoever sent you this before recording and it gets changed everywhere. Your clothing color only has to be true for "yesterday": wear it on camera if you can, but the lines work if you can't. The rest is flavor. Swap in your real life, your real subject, your real habits. True details get the biggest laughs.

The ask (email or text to each suspect)

Subject: 5 minutes of acting for the 4th grade Halloween party?

Hi [Name],

Mrs. Driscoll's class Halloween party on Oct 30 is a whodunit, and the kids are going to investigate four staff "suspects." Would you be one of the three who record a statement? All it takes is a 90-second video of yourself that you can record alone on your phone whenever you have a free minute. No one films you, no one edits you, and you don't need to attend the party.

Attached is your script. It's a monologue, so just talk to the camera. Quick tips:
• Phone horizontal, propped at face height, plain wall behind you
• Look just beside the lens, like a producer is sitting there
• Deadpan. Sincere. Slightly annoyed to be asked.
• Hold the pauses. Two takes max. Send me the raw video by [Oct 23].

The kids will watch it on the projector during the party and, I promise, lose their minds. Thank you!

[Your name] · [room parent for Mrs. Driscoll's class] · [phone]

The Custodian gets a different ask: "You're a suspect who declined to comment. That's it. That's the whole job. Please act shifty in the hallway on Oct 30."

VIDEO 1 · PLAYS AFTER STATION 1

VIDEO 1 — THE PRINCIPAL

self-recorded monologue, ~90 sec · The only interview with real information, and it arrives by accident. Deadpan. Hold the beats.

TITLE CARD · INTERVIEW 1 · THE PRINCIPAL · 9:12 AM

MAKE IT YOURS (read before you record)

- Must match the case file: "at a meeting" at [2:15] (your alibi), and that you own exactly one squishy, [a cat]. If you'd rather own a different one, tell the room parent so the suspect table says the same thing.
- Must match the real jar: "the big one, on the high shelf [by the window], with [three] strips of tape." Describe the actual jar in the actual spot.
- Free to change: [four minutes], the kind of meeting, [tie or collar], what the squishy is for. Add one true detail about yourself; it lands harder.
- Keep exactly: saying "squishies" by accident, then "candy," then trying to un-say it. That slip is the whole party.

Words in [brackets] are yours to adjust. Say them naturally, without the brackets.

(Sit. Look just beside the camera. Check your watch.)

I have a meeting in [four minutes], so let's make this quick.

You want to know where I was yesterday at [2:15]. I was in a meeting. I'm always in a meeting. Yesterday it was a meeting about the next meeting.

And you want to know what I know about the missing candy. Let me be very clear about this. I have not heard ANYTHING, and I know NOTHING, about anyone stealing the squishies.

(beat)

I mean candy.

(beat)

...Did I say squishies? What was I thinking! Candy. The candy. I know nothing about the candy.

(pause. Straighten your [tie or collar].)

I did not say squishies. I may have said squishies. It's a very common word. People say it all the time. In meetings. I am the principal of this school. I say a lot of words every day. Statistically, some of them are going to be "squishies."

(too fast)

And for the record, I have never even seen that jar. The big one. On the high shelf [by the window]. With the [three] strips of tape on the lid and the label that says "do not open."

(realize what you just said)

...Which I can only describe because people have described it to me. In meetings.

(pause)

Do I own any squishies myself? I'm the principal.

(beat)

...One. It's [a cat]. It's on my desk. It's for stress. This is stressful. (look at watch) I'm late.

(Stand up and walk out of frame. Leave the phone recording for 3 more seconds, then say, from off camera, slightly muffled:)

Is it off? Did it get the squishy thing? ...Can we cut the squishy thing?

(Then stop recording.)

Two takes max. Send the slightly flubbed one.